

GETTING OUT OF MYSELF # 36

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Understand the relationship between narcissistic traits and addiction.
2. Develop empathy for other people, particularly victims of the client's narcissism.
3. Identify past experiences of helping others and their positive effects.
4. List skills and abilities the client has that could be helpful to others.
5. Identify organizations or groups the client could help.
6. Create and carry out a plan to assist a group or organization of the client's choice.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE NARCISSISTIC TRAITS

- Being Genuinely Unselfish
- Correcting Distorted Thinking
- Forming Stable Relationships
- Learning to Ask Instead of Demand
- Seeing That We're All Just Human
- Understanding My Defense Mechanisms
- What Do I Want for My Children?

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The "Getting Out of Myself" activity is based on the 12-step principle of service work. One of the tenets of Alcoholics Anonymous is that when nothing else works to help a person stay sober, intensive work to help another alcoholic will succeed. This exercise presents this concept to the client, then guides him/her in identifying benefits of past experiences of helping others. It continues by identifying special skills or abilities the client has to offer, and groups he/she might want to assist, then creating a plan to engage in some form of formal or informal helping activity to reduce isolation, increase self-esteem, and get the client's emotional focus balanced between his/her own issues and those of others.

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Human connections have a healing power that helps us with many problems. Whether we are struggling with addictive patterns, depression, anxiety, grief, or physical illness, emotional isolation is often one of the sources of our problems and always makes it worse. Connecting emotionally with others on a meaningful level and doing things that get our focus off our problems and pain can help both us and them. It reduces our feelings of isolation, boosts our self-esteem, gives us the benefit of others' insights and experience, and lets us experience their interest in and regard for us. This is one of the core values of Alcoholics Anonymous and other 12--step programs, with their emphasis on what they call service work. This exercise will guide you in connecting with other people in ways that will enhance your recovery.

1. Think back to a time when you got involved with helping others in some way—raising money for a good cause, helping friends move, helping a child do homework, helping an elderly person with day--to--day tasks. What did you do and how did you feel about it?

2. Are you involved with any helping activities now, including service work in a 12--step program? ____ If so, what are you doing, what led you to get involved with this activity, and how does it contribute to your life today?

3. Use this space to list any special talents or training you have to offer (e.g., building or repairing things, teaching a skill, being multilingual, being artistic, being a good listener).

4. What organizations or groups of people could you volunteer to help out?

5. When during your typical day and week would you have some time to help others out?

6. Use this space to make a plan to contact a group that could use your help, find something you can do to help them, and make a schedule for this activity.
